First and foremost, a goal should tell readers specifically what you're trying to do ("encourage travellers to fly with Flying High"). But it should also describe why you want to do this and outline the business benefits you're trying to achieve by doing so ("increase ticket sales").

A goal should also be measurable. A measurable goal will give you a clearer idea of business expectations and also help you determine whether it has been achieved once the work is done. You can make a goal measurable by introducing notions of quantity and time. For example, "Increase ticket sales by 5% over the next year."

Quantifying a goal in this way will also make it much easier to determine how best to approach the problem, or whether the goal is even achievable in the first place. Increasing sales by 200% in 6 months would be quite a different proposition than increasing by 5% over the next year. Knowing the timeframe (6 months) also makes the goal more tangible and focused. In all of these cases, precise figures help manage expectations and ensure that everyone is on the same page.

But possibly the most important attribute of a good goal is its relevance. A goal is relevant if it will make a positive contribution to the organization in the current context within the specified timeframe, and if it is aligned with the overall strategy of the organization. Relevant goals are goals that will make a difference to the business.

3.4.2 Show me the money—business goals and revenue

Let's take a closer look at the business goals behind the Frequent Flyer program. A more complete list of goals might include the following:

- Increase ticket sales revenue by 5% over the next year by encouraging travellers to fly with Flying High rather than with a rival company.
- Increase the customer base by 10% within a year by building a positive image of the Frequent Flyer program.
- Avoid losing existing customers to the new rival Hot Shots Frequent Flyer program.
- Reduce hotline costs by enabling Frequent Flyer members to purchase flights with their points directly online, unlike the current program, where travellers need to call to make a booking.

Notice that the preceding goals all seem to boil down to earning more money, either by increasing revenue or by reducing costs. The goals of most commercial organizations are, by definition, ultimately financial in nature. In fact, almost all business goals can be grouped into one of the four following categories:

- Increasing revenue
- Reducing costs
- Protecting revenue
- Avoiding future costs

For example, "Increasing ticket sales revenue by 5%" (the first of the goals previously listed) is clearly about increasing revenue by selling more tickets. The second, "Increase